THE THIRSK DISASTER.

A TERRIBLE RAILWAY DISASTER.

The Wreck of the Scotch Express.

Ten Killed and Many Injured.

Overwork of the Signalman—Harrowing Scenes—A Survivor's Narrative—Statement by the Signalman.

EARLY on Wednesday morning, November 5, the East Coast express from Scotland to London collided with a goods train near Thirsk station, Yorkshire, with most disastrous results, 10 persons being instantly killed and a large number injured, some of them very seriously. The express, due to leave Edinburgh at 10.20 p.m. on Tuesday night, did not leave until 11.5, and all went well until arriving within three miles north of Thirsk, in the vicinity of Manor House siding. It seems that, owing to pressure of traffic, it was necessary to run not only a mail but a relief train, one following the other as soon as possible. The first to leave sped all right, but in the interval of one train passing and the other arriving near the Manor House siding a luggage train had been allowed to come along, and into it the express dashed with tremendous force, the result being terrible to contemplate. The time of the collision was a little after 4 o'clock in the morning, and a dense fog was then prevailing. The first part of

THE EXPRESS WAS TELESCOPED

by the terrible force of the impact with the rear of the other train, and the whole of it left the rails. The engine shot round almost at right angles to the line, and the vehicles following it, with the exception of the Pullman sleeping-car, were completely wrecked and heaped upon it in one huge pile. The Pullman car appears to have been detached from its wheels by the force of the collision, and by some means or other jerked forward, for it was afterwards found to be the leading vehicle. But however this may have occurred, the fact remains that only the front portion of the car was much shattered and that its occupants escaped with very slight injuries. Amongst them were the Marquis of Tweeddale (chairman of the North British Railway Co.), the Marquis of Huntley and General Lambton. The scene which followed the catastrophe was one of indescribable horror. The cries of the injured and dying rent the air, and in the gloom and fog of a chill November morning, with the lights of the train extinguished by the collision, the efforts of the more fortunate to rescue those who were buried in the wreckage were of little avail. To add to the terror of the panic and the sufferings of those who were in the most perilous position, the

FIRE OF THE ENGINE IGNITED THE WRECKAGE,

and in two cases at least victims of the disaster were literally roasted to death if they had not already succumbed to their fearful injuries. The guard of the rear van, Bean, appears to have been the first person to pull himself together, and with commendable promptitude he entered the signal-box, told the signalman to "block" the lines, and then, discovering that the train was foul of the down line, went forward to the next signal-box and fortunately succeeded in preventing the down mail, which was shortly due, from being also involved in disaster. Telegraph messages were at once sent to Mr. Welch (stationmaster at Thirsk), and he and Mr. Kirby (stationmaster at Otterington, whose signalman had heard the collision a mile and a half away), were quickly on the spot. Before leaving Thirsk Mr. Welch telegraphed to York, and at 5.25 a special train left for the scene of the disaster, conveying Mr. Harper (stationmaster), Mr. Steel (assistant passenger superintendent), and Dr. Tempest Anderson and Dr. Gostling. A number of members of the Ambulance Brigade also accompanied the party; and a breakdown gang, as well as the fire-engine of the company, subsequently followed. When Mr. Harper and the others arrived only one of the underneath coaches had become ignited, and a diligent search for bodies of injured passengers was begun. The flames, however, spread very rapidly, and soon the pile became one huge bonfire, which drove the rescuing party back and rendered their efforts futile. In the meantime the dead bodies of eight passengers had been discovered in the wreckage and removed to an adjoining field, and the injuries of the wounded were attended to by the medical men who had been summoned to the spot.

WAITING AT KING'S CROSS FOR THE SAVED.

A good many were sent on to London in a special train, which was timed to arrive at 1 o'clock on Wednesday afternoon, but which did not reach King's-cross Station until half an hour later. A large number of persons awaited its arrival, including friends of passengers who had heard some early news of the accident, and were anxious for further particulars. The approach of the train was notified by the report of a couple of fog signals. As it steamed into the station there was a general rush forward by those on the platform, while the carriage windows were scanned with keen and eager glances. There were some affecting scenes, relatives meeting each other and embracing

glances. There were some affecting scenes, relatives meeting each other and embracing with natural fervor and thankfulness.

KILLED.

R. M. Boyle, Augener and Co., Newgate-street.

H. P. Brodie, Wallwood-road, Leytonstone.

H. Lee, Spitalfields Market.

James J. Anderson, Dundee.

J. Boswell Hill, George-street, Edinburgh.

Captain M'Leod, 42nd Highlanders.

Miss M'Culloch, Alexandra, Dumbartonshire.

Lottie Hamilton, an infant, of the same address.

Thomas Petch, goods guard.

Mrs. M'Kenzie, Leven-street, Edinburgh.

INJURED.

Lady Stewart, 73 Harrington Gardens, London.

George Rhodes, Headingley, Leeds.

David Reid, Edinburgh.

David M'Culloch, head injured, Alexandria, Dumbartonshire.

Provost Sutherland, of Bathgate, near Edinburgh.

Mrs. Dodd, of Aberdeen.

Sarah Robinson, of Montrose.

Rose White, of the Boosey Theatrical Company.

Alexander M'Kenzie, Leven-street, Edinburgh.

J. H. Buchanan, Cardross, Fellow of Peterhouse College, Cambridge.

Ewart, driver of the express.

The fireman of the express.

Most of the above were only slightly injured, but the driver of the express has a broken thigh, and is in Thirsk Hospital.

INSURANCE GUARANTEES.

Several of the dead had upon them insurance tickets or current numbers of periodicals guaranteeing the payment of certain amounts in case of death by railway accident. Of the latter no less than six, representing altogether £2750, were found upon James J. Anderson.

The goods guard, Petch, was practically killed on the spot, and in most of the other cases death is stated to have been probably almost instantaneous. Petch, who leaves a wife and seven children, appears to have been standing outside his van when the collision took place, his body being found on the line terribly mangled.

NARROW ESCAPES.

Several marvellous escapes from almost certain death are related, and probably none is of a more remarkable nature than that of the conductor of the train named Wimpress, who resides in London. Wimpress' place in the train was in the front guard's van, which was completely wrecked, but in order that he might have his luggage and parcels, which were in the centre van, ready to put out at York, he changed from the front van to the centre van at Darlington, and though this vehicle was one of those which was heaped up on the top of the engine, he sustained no injury, and managed to

heaped up on the top of the engine, he sustained no injury, and managed to
crawl out of the window. Both the driver and the fireman of the express had narrow escapes from death. The former, whose name is Ewart, resides at Gateshead, and he sustained a broken thigh, whilst his companion is also stated to have been injured.

Both lines were blocked for some time, and the traffic had to be diverted. During the morning, however, the down line was cleared. The name of the signalman stationed at the Manor House siding-box is Holmes.

A CLERGYMAN'S STORY.

The Rev. J. S. Forsyth, in an interview on Wednesday evening with a representative of the CENTRAL NEWS, said:—"I was returning from Aberdeen. Everything proceeded very smoothly, and I was dozing in a corner of the carriage at the time of the occurrence. The other occupants of it were a young friend of mine—Mr. John Lumsden Stuart—and a lady, whose name I do not know, with her two children. I was ensconced in one corner of the carriage, my friend in the opposite one, and the lady and her two children had accommodated themselves on the seat opposite, where they were reposing. The train was rushing along at the rate of 60 miles an hour, when

THERE WAS A TREMENDOUS CRASH.

The light in the apartment was instantaneously extinguished. Then there was a quick recoil, followed by a second enormous crash. The roof of our carriage was driven in and a part of the side dislodged, while all the luggage on the racks, consisting of several portmanteaus, came tumbling upon our heads. The lady who was reposing on the seat opposite where I was sitting was thrown against me with so much violence that my shoulder was forced through the window. A deadly stillness succeeded the violent crash, and in the darkness our position may be more easily imagined than described. Fortunately Mr. Stuart had about him a candle and a match, and obtained for us in this way a light. Our first instinct was naturally as to how we were to get out. The lady passenger was shrieking with fright, but I did my best to pacify her, but her fears were not allayed by

THE FOLLY OF AN INDIVIDUAL

who, having liberated himself, went down the line shouting, 'There's another train coming along,' which, of course, was an alarm equally absurd and groundless. My friend first kicked the carriage door with his feet, but as that was no use I wrenched a large splinter of wood from the roof of our carriage and with it managed in a few minutes to force the door. The scene that presented itself to my gaze on looking first around was simply indescribable. To attempt to picture it in words would be impossible. The engine lay across a hedge, while upon the top of it, as if it had been going uphill, was the Pullman car, itself a frightful wreck, with both its ends completely knocked in, so that you could see straight through it, and one of its sides staved in entirely. My own carriage remained upright but tilted over. Both the first part and last part of the train was wholly wrecked. One of the ladies got her head so badly cut that although she

was wholly wrecked. One of the ladies got her head so badly cut that although she wanted to come on to London she had to be left behind at York. She was bleeding terribly about the skull. A few minutes after the collision the

CARRIAGES WENT ON FIRE,

and I don't believe there is a remnant of them left except the ironwork. The weather was cold, with a hoar frost, and we suffered the greatest discomfort until the arrival of the relief train from Thirsk about two hours later. A squad of about 40 men, some of whom were railway employees, arrived in the train that took us back to Thirsk, but ridiculously enough they had brought with them no implements or ambulances, so that the work of extricating the dead and dying had to be performed by improvised appliances. I heard one poor

LITTLE CHILD WHO WAS BURNT TO DEATH

shrieking for help, but nothing could be done for it, and the same occurred in the case of a young lady, who, unfortunately, poor creature, died amid the terrible wreckage. Lord Tweeddale, I may say, acted very kindly, and did all in his power to assist others, though how he escaped himself I cannot imagine. Amongst the dead and dying was one man who was in a dreadful state. He was fearfully cut about the head. He made desperate efforts to get out of the wreckage, and cried, 'Don't let me die.' He was covered with blood, so much so that I could not make out his features, or whether he was young or old. Lord Tweeddale came up to where this man was lying, and while a porter lifted him up and his lordship held a flask containing either brandy or whisky to his lips, I held up a carriage lamp. But the man could not swallow, and he died where he lay. There was another man with the back of his head all battered in. I think he was dead. Another man lay on his stomach in great distress. He also was so far gone that he could not swallow anything. The dead were all taken on to Thirsk and laid out on the floor, covered with rugs, in the general waiting-room.

"WITH REGARD TO THE SIGNALMAN,"

continues Mr. Forsyth, "he was in great mental distress when I went to see him, swaying his body to and fro in a condition of pitiable distraction. Speaking to a lady, I heard him say that he had lost a child the night previously. He had asked the stationmaster to allow him off duty, and the stationmaster refused to let him off. He was so tired that he fell fast asleep, and he did not signal at the right time, with the result that the goods train came on to the line without his knowing it. I must say that I think it was a shameful thing that a train loaded as this goods train was should have been allowed to stand on the main line in front of an express. We were conveyed back to Thirsk about 6 o'clock, and

OUR TREATMENT BY THE OFFICIALS

was not what it ought to have been. I complained in strong terms myself of the officials, and I also heard Lord Tweeddale speaking very severely to them. At Thirsk we were detained for a considerable time, perhaps unavoidably, while the bodies were being carried from the train to the waiting-room, but there was no necessity for our being transferred from this train to another in order to take us on to Northallerton, and having to wait there upwards of an hour, and then proceeding by another train to York, where we had a further wait of three-quarters of an hour, and had once more to change trains. Surely the least that the railway officials could have done would have been to despatch us by a special train direct to London, instead of changing us about as they did. We had no refreshment offered to us, and, as a matter of fact, from the time the collision occurred until I reached London I had eaten nothing. I have lost some of my luggage, and one lady that I travelled with who was in the accident, and who got her hand very severely cut, which was causing her great agony, had lost everything. Her dress was torn, she was without a bonnet and her hand was tied up in a shawl. Some of the passengers suffered more discomfort than others. Two gentlemen who were in the sleeping compartment were rushing about with no clothing except pyjamas."

STATEMENT BY HOLMES.

The special correspondent of the Press Association at Thirsk telegraphs that the signalman Holmes made an important statement on the subject of the railway catastrophe. He says that, after being on duty in his cabin for 12 hours, he returned home at 7 o'clock on Tuesday morning and retired to rest. His youngest child, which was not well, was placed in bed with him. Just before noon the child was seized with a convulsive fit. He got up and went for a doctor, and when he returned his baby was dead. Later on he applied to his superior officer, the stationmaster at Otterington, to be excused from duty, saying that he was

NOT FIT TO GO INTO THE SIGNAL-BOX

that night. The stationmaster replied that he would see what he could do, but subsequently said that he could not find a "sub." Holmes replied that in that event he would do his best, though he repeated that he did not feel fit for work. He went on duty at 8 o'clock, two hours after his proper time. He remembers the first portion of the express passing his cabin at 3.38, up to which time he had not felt a bit fatigued. After that time, he continued in relating his experiences,

"MY MIND BECAME CONFUSED.

Nothing seemed properly clear. I accepted the goods train in the ordinary way, but after that I took no more notice. I omitted to give the necessary signal to send the goods train on; indeed, I must have dropped asleep and the goods train remained stationary. The rear signalman woke me up by giving the notice to be ready for the express. I was confused with waking up, and, forgetting about the goods train, signalled the line clear for the express. At the same time the goods train, seeing the signal, moved forward, and the express having the line signalled 'All clear,' came rushing on and dashed into the rear of the goods train. As soon as I heard the express passing away from the other signal station I knew what was up; it was too late, and all I could do was to wait for the crash." While giving the above narrative to the

all I could do was to wait for the crash." While giving the above narrative to the special correspondent of the Press Association the signalman Holmes, who is a man about 27 years of age, and has been eight or nine years in the service of the North-Eastern Company, appeared to be much affected. He rested his head upon his hand and frequently gave way to tears.

OPENING OF THE INQUEST.

The inquest was opened in a large waiting-room at the Thirsk railway station on Thursday afternoon. The coroner said he would simply take evidence of identification, and adjourn the inquest. The Board of Trade inquiry would probably be held and completed in the meantime. The solicitor of the North-Eastern Co. expressed the great sorrow of the board of directors on account of the calamity, and deep sympathy with the relatives of the deceased. The jury then proceeded to view the bodies, and after they were identified the inquiry was adjourned for a fortnight.

Captain Duncan M'Leod, who is among the killed, was a son of Sir John M'Leod, late Governor of Ceylon, and was about 30 years of age. He had been in the army 10 years, and was in the Eastern Soudan campaign and the Nile expedition. He was present at the battles of El Teb, Tamai and Kirbekan. He was for two years in the depot of the 42nd Highlanders at Perth. He had been absent on leave, and should have shortly proceeded to his regiment at Gibraltar.

The result of the inquest by which Holmes, the signalman, was found guilty of manslaughter and bound over to appear when called on, has already been announced by cable.